



The Hollow Men

Mistah Kurtz - he dead.

T.S. Eliot

A Penny for the Old Guy

I

We are the hollow men
We are the stuffed men
Leaning together
5 Headpiece filled with straw. Alas!
Our dried voices, when
We whisper together
Are quiet and meaningless
As wind in dry grass
10 Or rats' feet over broken glass
In our dry cellar

Shape without form, shade without colour,
Paralysed force, gesture without motion;

15 Those who have crossed
With direct eyes, to death's other Kingdom
Remember us—if at all—not as lost
Violent souls, but only
20 As the hollow men
The stuffed men.

II

Eyes I dare not meet in dreams
25 In death's dream kingdom
These do not appear:
There, the eyes are
Sunlight on a broken column
There, is a tree swinging
30 And voices are
In the wind's singing
More distant and more solemn

Than a fading star.

35 Let me be no nearer
In death's dream kingdom
Let me also wear
Such deliberate disguises
Rat's coat, crowskin, crossed staves
40 In a field
Behaving as the wind behaves
No nearer—

Not that final meeting
45 In the twilight kingdom

III

This is the dead land
This is cactus land
50 Here the stone images
Are raised, here they receive
The supplication of a dead man's hand
Under the twinkle of a fading star.

55 Is it like this
In death's other kingdom
Waking alone
At the hour when we are
Trembling with tenderness
60 Lips that would kiss
Form prayers to broken stone.

IV

The eyes are not here
65 There are no eyes here

In this valley of dying stars
In this hollow valley
This broken jaw of our lost kingdoms

70 In this last of meeting places
We grope together
And avoid speech
Gathered on this beach of the tumid river

75 Sightless, unless
The eyes reappear
As the perpetual star
Multifoliate rose
Of death's twilight kingdom
80 The hope only
Of empty men.

V

Here we go round the prickly pear
85 *Prickly pear prickly pear*
Here we go round the prickly pear
At five o'clock in the morning.

90 Between the idea
And the reality

Between the motion
And the act
Falls the Shadow
For Thine is the Kingdom

95 Between the conception
And the creation
Between the emotion
And the response
Falls the Shadow
100 *Life is very long*

Between the desire
And the spasm
Between the potency
And the existence
105 Between the essence
And the descent
Falls the Shadow
For Thine is the Kingdom

For Thine is
110 Life is
For Thine is the

This is the way the world ends
This is the way the world ends
115 *This is the way the world ends*
Not with a bang but a whimper.

Pre-reading

- What emotions or images come to mind when you think of the term “hollow”? How might this relate to the poem’s themes?
- Based on what you know about Modernism, what themes or stylistic features do you expect to find in “The Hollow Men”?
- Consider the historical context of post-WWI Europe. How might the social and cultural atmosphere of the time influence the poem’s tone and content?
- Eliot often uses symbolism and allusion in his work. Keep an eye out for symbols that might represent broader themes of disillusionment, fragmentation, or the search for meaning. As an example, find out who the “Old Guy” is in the epigraph.
- How do you think “The Hollow Men” might reflect Eliot’s view of humanity and society at the time?

Post-reading

- Why are the figures described as “hollow”? What does their emptiness symbolise about society or humanity?
- Identify and analyse the imagery of desolation and decay in the poem. How do these images contribute to the overall mood and themes?
- “Eyes” are a recurring motif in the poem. Note each occurrence and discuss what they might represent.
- Eliot frequently employs contrasts and paradoxes (e.g., between life and death, presence and absence). Find examples of these and analyse how they deepen the poem’s exploration of existential themes.
- Pay attention to the poem’s structure and form, including its division into parts and its use of repetition and variation. How does the fragmented form reflect the themes of fragmentation and disconnection in the poem?
- Consider the tone and voice of the poem (funny, sad, optimistic, pessimistic, ironic, sarcastic, factual, etc.). How would you describe the speaker’s attitude toward the world he describes? How does the tone contribute to your understanding of the poem’s themes?
- Reflect on the poem’s conclusion. What significance do you find in the way the poem ends? How does this ending encapsulate the themes and emotions of the entire poem?